A wonderfully elegant soup that marks the crossover between foods that are coming into season and those that are going out of season.

soup of the first and last

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

10 oysters, opened, and with juice
1 tbsp butter
1 white onion, finely diced
2 garlic cloves, finely chopped
1 celery rib, finely diced
salt and freshly ground black pepper
¾ cup heavy cream
1¾ cups cold water
½ celeriac, peeled and finely diced
7oz (200g) russet potatoes, cut into thin slices
2 small–medium turnips, cut in two, then sliced into half-moons
7oz (200g) garlic leaves, cut into roughly 1¾in (4cm) pieces (or substitute baby spinach and extra garlic)
a handful of wild garlic flowers, to garnish (optional)

1 Wash 4–6 oyster shells (one per serving) to remove any grit. Cover with boiling water, to clean and keep warm. Heat the butter in a pan, add the onion, garlic, celery, and a pinch of salt, cover with a lid, and cook over low heat for 5 minutes or until soft. Add the cream, water, and celeriac and simmer, covered, for 10 minutes. Add the potatoes and cook for 10 minutes, then add the turnips and cook for 10 more minutes.

2 Take off the heat and ladle half the soup into a blender. Add 4–6 oysters (depending on how many you need to serve) and half the garlic leaves and blend until smooth. Tip the mixture back in the pan, rinse the blender out with 1¾ cups cold water, and add that to the pan as well. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper, add the rest of the garlic leaves, then bring to a gentle simmer and cook for 5 minutes.

3 Meanwhile, put the remaining oysters and their juices in a pan with 2 tbsp water, and poach for 4 minutes or until firm. Turn halfway through. Stir the juice (but not the oysters) into the soup, then check the seasoning and the consistency—add a little hot water if the soup is too thick. Divide among 4–6 bowls. Drop a warm oyster shell in each, fill with a poached oyster, and garnish with wild garlic flowers if desired.